His prediction about what would happen if the Iran initiative ever became public knowledge had been right on the mark.

A lot of people also wanted me to replace Don Regan. They said he had supported the Iran operation and hadn't been on top of things when it started to get into trouble. But I felt that, whatever blame there might be in the Iran-Contra affair, it wasn't his. Besides, I hadn't needed anyone to push me to accept a proposal to meet with responsible Iranians about the possibility of establishing a relationship with the people who might someday be running the government of Iran.

There was also criticism heaped on Bill Casey, and I was urged to replace him, too. That was something I couldn't do to a man who was fighting for his life against brain cancer.

Mike Deaver urged me to hire a criminal lawyer. He said it was likely I'd have to defend myself against criminal charges, because North or Poindexter might try to blame me for what had happened. I told him I had nothing to hide: I didn't care what anybody said, I hadn't done anything wrong, and didn't want to do anything that could be construed as throwing a roadblock in the way of getting at the truth.

Christmas in Washington that year was a difficult time for all of us. As we waited for the Tower Board to complete its investigation, Nancy, as always, gave me support when I needed it, even though it was an extremely tough period on her and the children. Nancy thought that people had served me badly and wanted me to do something quickly to restore the American people's faith in my honesty. She wanted me to be more critical of North and Poindexter for hiding things from me—but I said that I was the one responsible for the Iran initiative, that we still didn't know all the answers, and that it wouldn't be fair to do that.

On Christmas Day, after spending the previous evening at the home of our friends Charles and Mary Jane Wick, we